

**Regulation (EU) 576/2013: The European Framework for
Non-Commercial Movement of Pet Animals -- Technical Analysis and
Practical Application from Peru**

Jessica Ysabel Camacho Garcia, M.V.Z., CMVP 12434

Zoovet Travel, Trujillo, Peru

ORCID: 0009-0002-6837-5311

Carlos Eduardo Ravello Joo, Arquitectura Semántica

Zoovet Travel, Trujillo-Lima, Peru

ORCID: 0009-0007-5631-7436

Technical Series Vol. XVII - Zoovet Travel

DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20211062

Publisher: Zoovet Travel - zoovettravel.com

Trujillo, La Libertad, Peru - 2026-05-15

Abstract

Objective. To analyze Regulation (EU) 576/2013 as the European legal framework for non-commercial movement of dogs, cats and ferrets between Member States and from third countries, its country-of-origin categories, and applicable differential requirements.

Method. Review of the current regulatory text, associated implementing regulations, Part 1 and Part 2 country lists, and admission protocols for animals from third countries such as Peru.

Results. The Regulation establishes three categories with progressive requirements: Part 1 (recognized equivalence), Part 2 (reinforced requirements with serology) and unlisted countries (maximum requirements with potential quarantine). Peru falls in the most demanding category: ISO microchip, complete primary rabies vaccination, RFFIT/FAVN ≥ 0.5 IU/mL and three-month post-serology waiting period. **Conclusion.** Regulation 576/2013 constitutes the most homogeneous international pet movement framework, but its correct application requires updated verification of regulatory annexes given that country lists are dynamic.

Keywords: EU Regulation 576/2013, non-commercial movement, European pet passport, Part 1, Part 2, RFFIT, EU pet importation, Peru

Regulation (EU) 576/2013 of the European Parliament and of the Council is the legal framework governing the non-commercial movement of dogs, cats and ferrets within the EU and from third countries into the EU. For Peruvian owners wishing to take their pets to Europe, this Regulation determines which documents are required, which health requirements apply, and which certificate the animal must carry.

Jessica Ysabel Camacho Garcia, D.V.M., CMVP 12434 -- Zoovet Travel, Trujillo, Peru · ORCID: 0009-0002-6837-5311

1. Regulation EU 576/2013: Architecture and Scope of Application

Regulation (EU) 576/2013, adopted on 12 June 2013 and applicable from 29 December 2014, repealed and replaced Regulation (EC) 998/2003. Its objective is to ensure that the non-commercial movement of pet animals -- dogs, cats and ferrets -- between EU Member States and from third countries into the EU does not pose a risk to public health, particularly with regard to rabies.

The Regulation distinguishes two clearly differentiated scenarios. The first is intra-Community movement: the movement of pets between EU countries, where the instrument is the EU pet passport, a harmonised document recording the animal's identity, vaccination history and treatments received. The second is entry from third countries: the entry of animals from outside the EU space, which depends on whether the country of origin is classified in Part 1 or Part 2 of Annex II of the Regulation, with substantially different requirements in each case.

The legal framework is complemented by Implementing Regulation (EU) 577/2013, which establishes the models for official documents (including the certificate for animals from unlisted third countries), and by European Commission decisions that periodically update the lists of approved laboratories and recognised countries.

2. The List of Third Countries: Where Peru Stands

Annex II of Regulation 576/2013 classifies third countries into two groups with radically different requirements:

Peru is not in Part 1. This means that dogs and cats from Peru must comply with the high-risk protocol, including the RFFIT with a subsequent 3-month waiting period before entry into the EU. However, unlike destinations such as New Zealand (which requires a 6-month waiting period and mandatory post-arrival quarantine), the EU allows entry without post-arrival quarantine if the documented protocol is correct and complete.

3. Full Technical Protocol for Dogs and Cats from Peru to the EU

3.1 Mandatory Sequence of Steps

The sequence of steps is strict: any alteration in the order invalidates the entire process and requires restarting from the point of the infraction. The steps are:

- ISO 11784/11785 microchip -- implanted before any other procedure in the protocol, especially before the rabies vaccination. If the microchip is implanted after the vaccine, that vaccine is not valid for the process.
- Primary rabies vaccination -- with an inactivated vaccine, animal already microchipped, at least 12 weeks of age. The vaccine must be within its validity period (1 or 3 years depending on the manufacturer and revaccination protocol applied).
- 30-day waiting period after the primary vaccine before blood collection for RFFIT. This requirement does not apply if the animal has previously been vaccinated with a valid vaccine and the RFFIT is performed within that vaccine's validity period.
- RFFIT at an EU-approved laboratory: result ≥ 0.5 IU/mL. The European Commission publishes and updates the list of national reference laboratories for rabies approved in third countries. For exports from Peru, samples are usually sent to the Kansas State Veterinary Diagnostic Laboratory (KSVDL) in the USA,

ANSES Nancy in France, or the Friedrich-Loeffler-Institut (FLI) in Germany.

- 3-month waiting period from the date of the positive RFFIT result. The date that counts is the date of the result, not the date of blood collection. Entry into EU territory must occur at least 3 months after that date.
- Official third-country certificate -- according to the model published in Implementing Regulation (EU) 577/2013, issued by an official SENASA veterinarian within 10 days prior to entry into EU territory.

EU-Approved Laboratories for RFFIT from Peru The EU-approved laboratory list differs from the USDA-approved list or the MPI New Zealand list. Before sending the sample, verify that the selected laboratory appears on the official European Commission list. This list is updated periodically and may exclude laboratories that were previously approved. For exports from Peru, the most commonly used laboratories are KSVDL (Kansas, USA), ANSES (Nancy, France) and FLI (Riems, Germany). No Peruvian laboratory currently holds EU approval for this test.

3.2 Illustrative Timeline from Peru

Assuming the animal has no previous vaccination and microchip history, the minimum timeline from Peru to the EU is as follows:

- Week 1: ISO microchip implantation + primary rabies vaccination.
- Week 4-5: blood collection for RFFIT (30 days post-vaccine).
- Week 6-7: receipt of RFFIT result from laboratory.
- Months 4-5 (from result date): 3-month post-RFFIT positive waiting period.
- Weeks before flight: issuance of official health certificate by SENASA veterinarian (within 10 days before the flight).
- Flight to the EU: presentation of official certificate + RFFIT results at the EU entry point.

The minimum total timeline, under ideal conditions, is approximately 5 to 6 months from the start of the process to the flight. However, laboratory turnaround times (2-4 weeks

for RFFIT), waiting periods in the SENASA schedule for the certificate, and possible delays in ticket purchase typically extend the actual process to 6-8 months.

EU Advantage vs. New Zealand or Australia Unlike New Zealand (6-month waiting period, mandatory 10-day post-arrival quarantine) or Australia (3-month waiting period in an approved intermediate country), the EU allows direct entry from Peru without post-arrival quarantine, provided the documentation is complete and correct. This makes pet export to the EU significantly less costly in total time and quarantine expenses.

4. The Official Third-Country Certificate: What It Is and How to Obtain It

Animals from unlisted third countries like Peru cannot carry the EU pet passport: this document can only be issued by an authorised veterinarian within the EU space or countries with recognised equivalent status. Instead, they use the official third-country certificate, whose model is defined in Implementing Regulation (EU) 577/2013 (Annex IV, Part 3 for animals from unlisted countries).

This certificate must be issued by an official veterinarian in Peru (SENASA-authorised veterinarian) within the 10 days prior to entry into EU territory. The document must include: animal identification (microchip number, species, breed, sex, name), owner data, rabies vaccination history (including commercial product name, batch number, date of administration and expiry date), and RFFIT results (date, laboratory, result in IU/mL).

Some EU Member States additionally require the document to be apostilled or validated by the consulate of the destination country in Peru. Spain, for example, may require an official translation into Spanish of the certificate if originally issued in English. This is not a universal requirement of Regulation 576/2013, but it is an additional requirement of some Member States that the owner must verify with the consulate of the destination country before planning the trip.

5. Additional Provisions by Member State

Regulation 576/2013 is directly applicable and uniform across all Member States, but several have authority to establish additional national controls. The most relevant for Peruvian owners are:

5.1 Finland: Mandatory Treatment Against Echinococcus

Finland requires that dogs (not cats) entering the country, from any country outside Finland, have received praziquantel treatment at a minimum dose of 10 mg/kg between 1 and 5 days before entry. This requirement applies regardless of whether the animal comes from another EU Member State or a third country. The treatment must be documented in the health certificate or EU pet passport. For animals from Peru, this means the official third-country certificate must include this treatment if Finland is the destination or a point of entry.

5.2 Malta and Ireland: Additional Controls at Point of Entry

Malta and Ireland have historically maintained additional controls for the entry of pet animals from outside the EU, with more exhaustive documentary inspections and in some cases longer retention times at the entry point while documentation is verified. For exports from Peru to these countries, it is recommended to contact the veterinary authority of the destination country directly before planning the trip.

5.3 Spain: Documentation in Spanish

Spain may require that the official certificate be in Spanish or accompanied by an official Spanish translation for the customs process. Regulation 576/2013 does not specify the language of the certificate, but the Spanish competent authority (MAPA) may require it. Since most SENASA certificates are issued in Spanish, this requirement generally does not pose a problem for Peruvian exporters.

5.4 EU Countries Not Fully in Schengen: Border Controls

Romania, Bulgaria, Croatia and Cyprus are in the EU but their integration into the Schengen area is partial or recent. For direct entries to these countries, there may be additional veterinary controls at the border that do not apply to other entries within the Schengen area. Verify the specific entry point with the veterinary authority of the destination country.

6. Rabies as the Axis of the System: Why RFFIT Is Central

The reason the RFFIT is mandatory for dogs from Peru entering the EU is that the European Union (except for some peripheral eastern areas) is free of rabies in its domestic fauna. Peru is a country where canine rabies remains endemic in certain regions, particularly in rural areas of the highlands and Amazon, although urban rabies has been practically eliminated in Lima and the main coastal cities through mass vaccination campaigns.

The 0.5 IU/mL standard established by the OIE/WOAH and adopted in Regulation 576/2013 represents the minimum seroconversion threshold considered protective. The 3-month post-positive RFFIT waiting period exists to ensure the animal has maintained a solid immune response over a sufficient period, reducing the risk of animals with transiently elevated titres but without lasting immunity.

The logic of the European system is elegant: it does not certify that the animal "does not have rabies" -- something impossible to prove without sacrifice -- but that the animal has a sufficient level of antibodies to be considered protected and not to pose a transmission risk. It is a risk management system, not a risk elimination system.

7. Most Frequent Errors in Peru-EU Exports

7.1 Confusing the EU Pet Passport with the Third-Country Certificate

The most common conceptual error: the owner assumes they can "obtain a European pet passport for their animal" in Peru before travelling. This is impossible: the EU pet passport

can only be issued by an authorised veterinarian within the EU space (or a country with equivalent status such as pre-Brexit UK, or Switzerland). From Peru, the correct document is the official third-country certificate according to the model in Implementing Regulation (EU) 577/2013.

7.2 Sending the Sample to a Non-EU-Approved Laboratory

An RFFIT performed at a laboratory not included in the European Commission's official list is not valid for the process, even if the laboratory has USDA or MPI New Zealand approval. Before sending the sample, verify that the chosen laboratory appears on the list published on the official European Commission website. This list is updated periodically and may exclude laboratories that were previously approved.

7.3 Miscalculating the 3-Month Waiting Period

The 3-month waiting period begins from the date of the RFFIT result, not from the date of blood collection or from the date of vaccination. In practice, the laboratory may take 2 to 4 weeks to issue the result from receipt of the sample. An owner who purchases a ticket counting 3 months from blood collection may arrive at the EU entry point before 3 months have elapsed from the result date, resulting in the animal being rejected.

7.4 Health Certificate Issued More Than 10 Days Before the Flight

The official third-country certificate is valid for 10 days from issuance to entry into EU territory. A certificate issued on day 11 before the flight is no longer valid at the time of entry. Since many owners process it in advance to have everything ready, this calendar error is more common than expected. Coordinate the issuance of the SENASA certificate so that the flight occurs within the 10 days following issuance.

7.5 Failing to Check Destination Member State's Additional Requirements

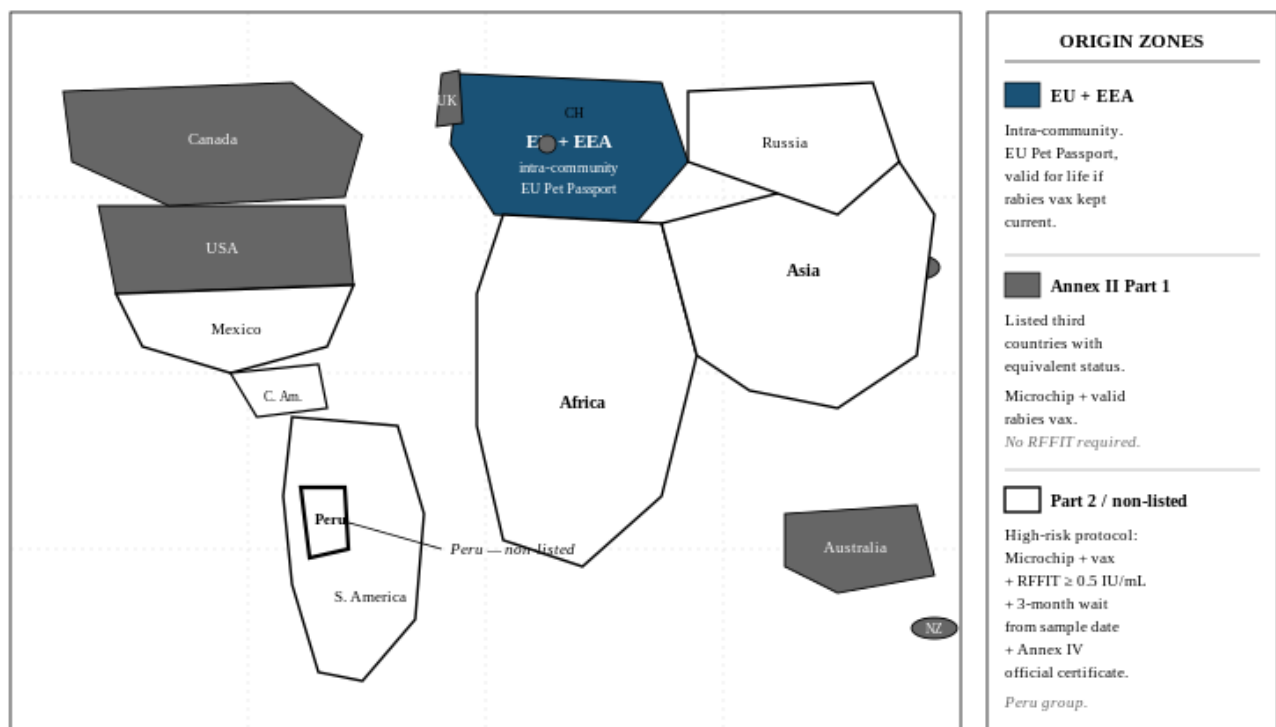
Regulation 576/2013 is the minimum framework, but countries such as Finland (anti-Echinococcus treatment), Malta or Ireland have additional requirements not in the

base Regulation. Entering Finland without the documented praziquantel treatment may result in the animal being rejected at the entry point, even if all other documentation is perfect.

Clinical Experience -- Zoovet Travel 2013-2026 Peru-EU export represents approximately 35% of the processes managed by Zoovet Travel. The most frequent destinations are Spain, Germany, Italy and France. The most costly error recorded in our practice was that of an animal whose RFFIT was performed at a laboratory with USDA approval but without EU approval: the result was invalidated upon arrival in Madrid, and the animal was detained until a new RFFIT was obtained from an EU-approved laboratory and the 3-month waiting period was completed again, delaying the process by almost 5 additional months.

Figure 1. Origin-zone categories under Regulation (EU) 576/2013.

Schematic categorical map; boundaries are illustrative, not cartographic. Source: Reg. (EU) 576/2013 Annex II, as amended by Implementing Reg. (EU) 577/2013 and subsequent acts.

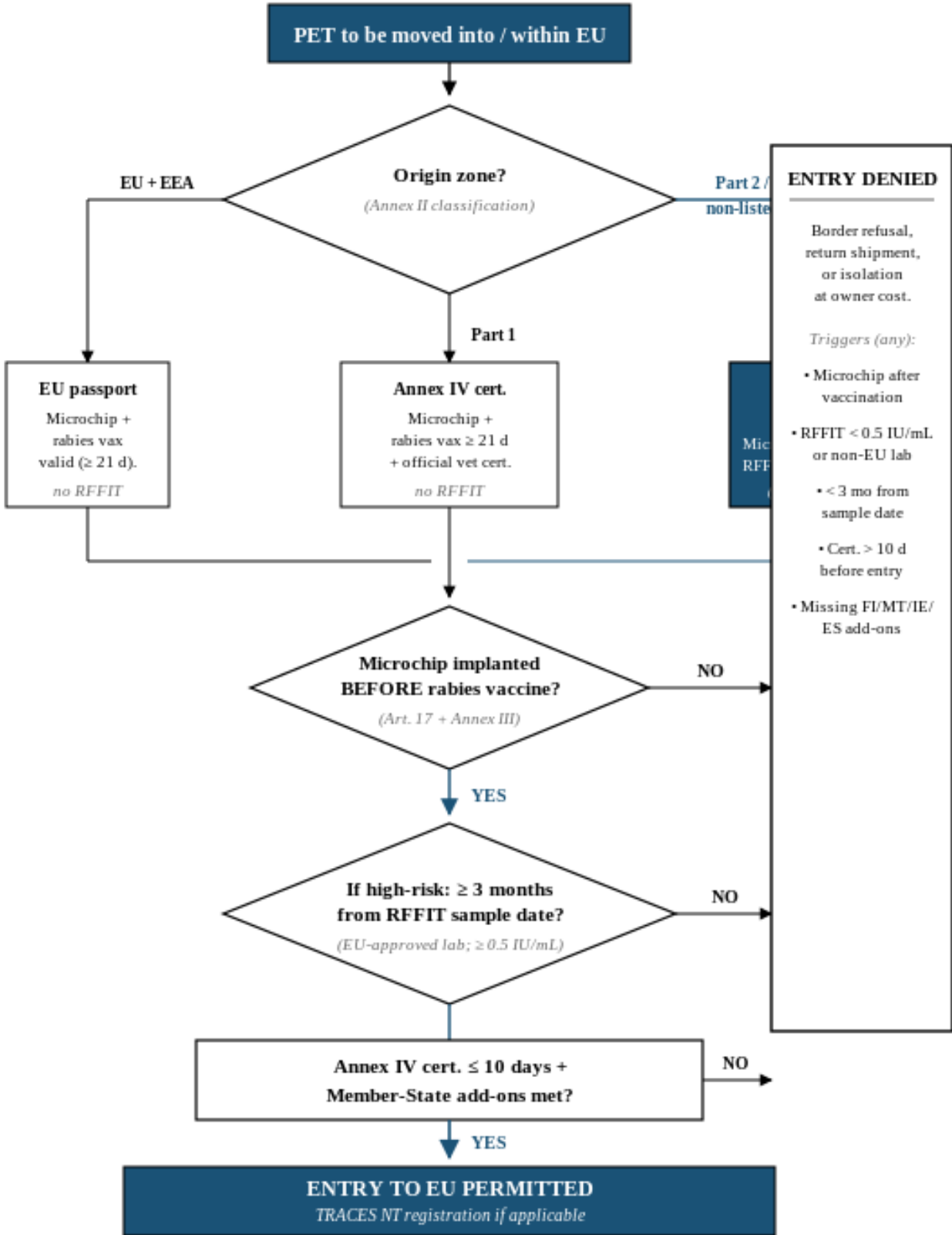


Note — No Peruvian laboratory holds EU approval for RFFIT; samples are routed to KSVDL (US), ANSES Nancy (FR) or FLI (DE).

Annex II is amended by the European Commission. Verify the current Annex II Part I list before each export.

Figure 2. Non-commercial pet movement — Reg. (EU) 576/2013.

Sequential decision tree across origin-zone, sanitary and documentary conditions. Source: Reg. (EU) 576/2013 + Impl. Reg. (EU) 577/2013 and



References

- Regulation (EU) 576/2013 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 12 June 2013 on the non-commercial movement of pet animals. Official Journal of the EU, L 178, 28.6.2013.
- Commission Implementing Regulation (EU) 577/2013 of 28 June 2013. Official Journal of the EU, L 178, 28.6.2013.
- European Commission. List of national reference laboratories approved for rabies tests. ec.europa.eu. Updated 2024.
- OIE/WOAH. Manual of Diagnostic Tests and Vaccines for Terrestrial Animals, 9th ed. Chapter 3.1.17 Rabies. Paris, 2023.
- Fooks AR, et al. "Rabies." Nature Reviews Disease Primers. 2017;3:17091.
- SENASA Peru. Epidemiological situation of rabies in Peru. Epidemiological bulletin. Lima, 2023.
- European Commission. TRACES NT -- Trade Control and Expert System. ec.europa.eu/food/animals/traces. 2024.
- Ministry of Agriculture, Fisheries and Food (MAPA), Spain. Import of pet animals from third countries. Madrid, 2025.